Administration presents its own challenges, especially tackling the perception of endemic sloth. A blitz of directives from the Rajasthan High Court only accentuated it. On August 7, embarrassingly, it directed departments to acknowledge citizen complaints within 30 days. Three days later, it ordered senior police brass in four districts to spend an hour a day in their police stations to personally monitor investigations. On August 28, it even went against the state's stand to cancel the 2021 sub-inspectors' recruitment exam.

The sense of drift comes despite the CM's daily review meetings, and feedback from wherever he can, but has not yet built a trusted core team around him. Most CMs rely on such an elite corps to get things going as well as manage perceptions.

The absence was felt acutely in recent weeks as a series of school building collapses killed nine students in different districts. The tragedies exposed glaring mismanagement: neither had enough money been allocated for repair, nor were available funds properly spent. Minister Madan Dilawar has been more occupied with prescribing teachers' dress codes and reshaping school syllabuses to fit the BJP's ideological agenda than with basic safety.

Takeaways

- **Post a series of unflattering events, Bhajan Lal Sharma seeks to recoup his image**
- **Dangles the prospect of a cabinet reshuffle, to keep the political field under control**
- **Tries to erase the charge of administrative sloth after HC pulls up officials, police brass**
- **A series of school building collapses, with nine students dead, sparks public outrage**
- **Two arrests keep alive the spectre of corruption**

the two dozen-plus surprise inspections carried out over the past 20 months by chief secretary Sudhansh Pant. Insiders claim the system is still being gamed: files are often shuffled late at night merely to appear "disposed of" in the digital monitoring system, when in reality they continue to circle aimlessly.

A SENSE OF DRIFT

It goes beyond paperwork. The state empowered committee, meant to fast-track major investment proposals, has barely met. Inter-departmental disputes—on mining/environmental clearances in Chittorgarh, tender approvals in public health et al—remain unresolved. A former bureaucrat familiar with the CM's Office says the root cause is structural: Sharma is accessible and seeks

Stung by public outrage, Sharma cracked the whip, ordering unsafe buildings to be abandoned and thousands of others to be repaired. But mortifyingly, the Anti-Corruption Bureau struck, catching an accounts officer and a middleman red-handed while accepting a Rs 1 lakh bribe to clear bills for school construction in Sikar on August 13. The next day, a cooperative department inspector was arrested for taking Rs 2.75 lakh to influence a land dispute in a housing society.

Sharma insists he's stemming the rot, and "the corrupt are being caught". He has fast-tracked land allotments and approvals on MoUs signed during last year's Rising Rajasthan summit, offering alternate sites if necessary. But what he needs to secure is some good political territory around himself—and fast. ■

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA MODI CHOSE the virtual launch of a Bihar women's self-help cooperative on September 2 to break his silence. "My mother had nothing to do with politics," he said, voice heavy with hurt, referencing the viral video of a minor abusing his late mother in Darbhanga on August 27, seeking to turn a personal wound into a national lament. That he framed it as an affront to "every mother, sister and daughter in India" wasn't a random ethical point. It was careful targeting.

Bihar's women are powerful, engaged voters. In the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, with a 59.45 per cent turnout, they vastly outnumbered men (53 per cent). And in the past decade, the Modi-Nitish Kumar duo have held a strong appeal for women voters, built around social sector schemes, presented as an antithesis to the 'jungle raj' image trap of the RJD.

Yet alongside that is playing out a deeper churn—a historic generational shift. The most telling statistic in Bihar's evolving polity: 57 per cent of its population is below 35. Rival parties have been quicker on the transition. It's a whole gallery of political heirs out there: RJD's Tejashwi Yadav (35), LJP's Chirag Paswan (44), HAM supremo Jitan Ram Manjhi's son Santosh Suman (50). The newly minted neta, Prashant Kishor (45), too, rides that surf.

Amidst this greening, the BJP finds itself in a bind. It lacks a clear generational face in Bihar to match the moment. Though the party is buoying up its young leaders—minister Nitin Nabin (45), national secretary Rituraj Sinha (45) and Dalit leader-cum-spokesperson